

Build a reminder system from a spreadsheet

AI Work Session | Eastern Mennonite University | Wednesday, August 19

The situation

You have a list of people who each need to submit something, at different stages. Some have never been reminded. Some you reminded once. A few you have reminded twice and heard nothing back.

This exercise shows you how you could build a reminder system that decides who is due for a nudge and generates your email drafts directly in Gmail, with copy that changes based on the row.

Round one: get it running

1. Open the practice roster and go to **File > Make a copy**. Work in your own copy.
2. Open **gemini.google.com** and paste the prompt in the box below.
3. Copy the code it gives back.
4. In your sheet, go to **Extensions > Apps Script**. Click the project name at the top left and rename it **Reminder machine** - you will see that name again in a moment.
5. Delete everything in the editor, paste the code, and click the save icon.
6. Go back to the sheet and **reload the page**. A new menu appears in the toolbar.
7. Click it. See page two for the permission screen you are about to hit.

The prompt

I use a Google Sheet to track students who each need to complete a requirement. I want a Google Apps Script that decides who needs a reminder and writes the emails for me.

The sheet has one tab called Roster with these columns in this order: Name, Email, Item needed, Status, Due date, Reminders sent, Last reminder. Row 1 is headers. Status is one of Not started, Started, or Complete. Reminders sent is a number. Last reminder is a date or blank.

Here is a sample row so you can see the shape:

Avery Nolan | avery.nolan@example.com | Immunization record | Not started | 2026-08-01 | 0 | (blank)

Go through every row and apply these rules:

- If Status is Complete, skip the row.
- If the due date has not passed, skip the row.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 0, create a first reminder.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 1 and Last reminder was 7 or more days ago, create a second, firmer reminder.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 2 and Last reminder was 7 or more days ago, do not write an email. Add the person to a tab called Needs a call instead.

The emails should be short and warm, address the person by first name, name the specific item they owe, and mention the due date.

Important requirements:

- Create Gmail drafts. Do not send anything.
- After drafting, increase Reminders sent by one and put today's date in Last reminder.
- Add a menu to the spreadsheet called Reminders with one item that runs this.
- When it finishes, show me a popup summarizing how many first reminders, second reminders, and calls came out of the run.
- Add comments explaining what each section does, because I don't write code.

Notice what you did not do: you never showed Gemini a single student. It saw column names, one invented row, and your rules. The code came back, and the code runs where the data already lives.

The permission screen

Everyone hits this. Nothing has gone wrong.

Two screens stand between you and a working script. Neither one means you broke something.

First screen - “Authorization required.” It offers Cancel and Review permissions. Cancel looks like the safe button. It is not the one you want.

Click **Review permissions**, and confirm your EMU account.

Second screen - the permission grant. It names your script and lists what it wants access to.

Check **every** box. Use **Select all**. A partial grant fails later in a way that looks like broken code.

Then click the button at the bottom to continue.

Read that screen before you click

One line says: **“Read, compose, send, and permanently delete all your email from Gmail.”** That should get your attention. Three things are true about it:

- **The app asking is yours.** The screen says **Reminder machine**, because you typed that a minute ago. The thing requesting access to all your email is the code you pasted ninety seconds ago.
- **The ask is broad because it has to be.** Apps Script requests Gmail access at the account level. There is no drafts-only permission to grant.
- **You can take it back.** Go to myaccount.google.com/permissions any time and revoke it in about four clicks.

If nothing happens

- No new menu? Reload the sheet, and check you saved in the Apps Script editor.
- Wrong people getting emails? Check the column order matches what you told Gemini.
- Still stuck? Raise a hand. A flagged failure is worth more here than a quiet success.

Check your work

A correct script produces exactly this from the practice roster:

Outcome	How many	Who
First reminder	2	Avery Nolan, Morgan Ellis
Second reminder	2	Jordan Reyes, Priya Raman
Needs a call	1	Sam Okonkwo
Skipped	3	Riley Chen, Devon Marsh, Kai Whitfield

Three people are skipped for three different reasons. If your script skipped them for the wrong reasons, it still looks like it worked. That is the whole lesson.

Round two: make it yours

Pick one. They get harder as you go down.

- Change the tone of the second reminder, or add a third one.
- Add a column for the office that owns each item, and sign the email from that office.
- Send yourself one daily digest of everyone overdue instead of individual drafts.
- Write a different message depending on which item is missing.
- Make it run itself every Monday morning.

Before you leave: what is the list you actually chase at work? Write it on your exit ticket.